This theme of communalism—Nehru attacking the Sangh and Mookerjee defending his party—became a recurrent theme in the political exchanges between the two sides in that first election for India. Only three years had passed since Mahatma Gandhi had been murdered by an assassin who justified his actions in court by arguing that what he saw as the Mahatma's Muslim appeasement was, in his view, an impediment to Hindu rights.[15] Thousands of Hindu and Sikh refugees of Partition were still parked in camps across Delhi, West Bengal, Assam and Tripura. Nehru made this the central issue of independent India's first election. Communalism has, in the past, 'separated the people … and led to India's enslavement,' he declared. 'Whatever the proposed aim of those who spread communalism, their activities only weakened the foundations of freedom.'[16]

Three Internal Debates that Shaped Nehru vs Jan Sangh Battles: the Congress, the RSS and Mookerjee

Mookerjee, a brilliant lawyer from Bengal who had trained at London's Lincoln's Inn and served as vice chancellor of Calcutta University (1934–1938), had started his political career as a Congressman when he was elected to the Bengal Legislative Council in 1929. He quit the party a year later, getting re-elected from the same constituency as an independent in 1931, and subsequently joined the Hindu Mahasabha on 'encouragement from its president, Veer Savarkar' and from RSS chief Dr Keshav Baliram Hedgewar.[17] Mookerjee left the Mahasabha in May 1949, while he was still serving as Nehru's minister, because he opposed both its decision to turn itself into a political party and its reluctance to give membership to non-Hindus—something he had been pushing for since 1945.[18]

Mookerjee's decision to subsequently resign from Nehru's cabinet in 1950, protesting the newly independent nation's attitude to Hindu minorities in Pakistan, did not lead only to the creation of the Jan Sangh. It also focused attention on an issue that would become the lightning rod in key debates between Hindu nationalists and